Task 5: Cybercrime Awareness Case Study & Prevention Guide

Case Study (The Ten-Minute Phone Call That Brought Las Vegas to a Standstill)

Picture the Las Vegas strip. The flashing lights, the constant dinging of slot machines, the endless flow of people and money. Now, imagine someone simply pulls the plug on all of it.

In September 2023, that nightmare became a reality for MGM Resorts. Slot machines went dark. ATMs stopped spitting out cash. Digital restaurant menus crashed, and even the electronic keys to the hotel rooms stopped working. It was pure chaos for days. But the wildest part of the story isn't *what* happened—it's *how* it happened.

You might picture a team of elite hackers typing furiously in a dark basement, smashing their way through complex digital firewalls like in a Hollywood movie. The reality? It was just a ten-minute phone call.

The hackers simply scrolled through LinkedIn, found the profile of a real MGM employee, and jotted down some basic, public information. Then, they called the MGM IT help desk. They put on a convincing voice, pretended to be that employee, and spun a totally relatable story: *"Hey, I lost my phone and I'm locked out of my account. Can you help me out?"*

The IT worker on the other end of the line wasn't careless; they were just being a good coworker. Wanting to help a colleague in a bind, they reset the password and bypassed the security checks. And just like that, the hackers were handed the keys to the kingdom. Once inside, they unleashed ransomware that brought the entire casino empire to its knees, forcing stressed-out staff to write receipts by hand, dig up physical metal room keys, and manually check in thousands of exhausted guests.

The financial hit was brutal—costing the company an estimated $100 million. But the biggest takeaway is a humbling one. You can buy the most expensive, state-of-the-art cybersecurity software in the world, but your biggest vulnerability is always human nature. We naturally want to be helpful, and unfortunately, that is exactly what cybercriminals count on.